

METHODOLOGICAL GUIDE

NVivo for thematic analysis

AUTHOR

E. Ryckewaert
Univ. Lille, CNRS, UMR 9193 — SCALab
Cognitive and Affective Sciences
F-59000 Lille, France

READ THIS FIRST

NVivo is a tool for **managing and exploring** qualitative data. It does not perform the analysis and does not identify themes: every analytical decision remains the researcher's.

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Purpose of the guide

Practical guidance for organising, coding, exploring and managing qualitative data in NVivo — written for researchers working with interviews, focus groups or open-ended responses. It sets out the principles of thematic analysis and shows how the software can support each step of the reasoning, without ever standing in for it.

The screenshots, example codes and thematic tree come from a fictitious project on the effects of a couples' support intervention — adapt them to your own material.

WHO FOR Anyone working on a qualitative corpus	UPSTREAM To produce the transcripts: <i>Whisper transcription guide</i>
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1 Understanding thematic analysis

1.1 — What it is

Thematic analysis is a qualitative method for identifying, analysing and interpreting *themes* within a corpus. It is used to explore participants' experiences, perceptions, opinions and representations.

It moves from raw data towards progressively more structured interpretation:

01 Raw data	02 Codes	03 Categories	04 Themes	05 Interpretation
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1.2 — Choosing a methodological approach

Thematic analysis comes in several approaches, which differ in their assumptions about the researcher's role, the status of coding and the way themes are built. The table below situates the three most cited approaches; it is not meant to be exhaustive.

APPROACH	POSITION ON THEMES	INTER-CODER AGREEMENT	REFERENCE
Reflexive TA	Themes are <i>constructed</i> by the researcher; subjectivity is a resource, not a bias.	Not required, and discouraged as a quality criterion.	Braun & Clarke (2021, 2022)
Codebook TA	Coding frame defined in advance then refined; themes partly pre-structured.	Common, on a subset, to stabilise the frame.	Gale et al. (2013)
Coding reliability TA	Themes treated as categories to be identified reliably in the data.	Central; kappa reported in the results.	Boyatzis (1998)

Table 1 – the three families of thematic analysis and what each expects regarding reliability.

A DECISION TO TAKE BEFORE CODING

Thematic analysis is not a software-specific method: NVivo supports all three approaches equally. The choice follows from the research question and the study design, **before** coding, and it determines in particular whether an agreement coefficient is computed at all (7.2).

1.3 — The six steps

01

Familiarise

Read and reread the corpus, note first impressions. No coding at this stage.

02

Code

Identify meaningful segments and assign a code to them. §5

03**Organise**

Bring related codes together; let broader patterns surface. §6.1

04**Develop the themes**

Review, name, delimit. A theme must hold without the corpus in front of you. §6.2

05**Interpret**

Relate the themes to the research question and the literature.

06**Report**

Present the findings, supported by selected extracts. §9

THE PROCESS IS ITERATIVE

The steps are not a tunnel. You will regularly go back as your grasp of the corpus sharpens: a theme from step 04 sends you back to codes from step 02, and that is normal.

2 Understanding NVivo

2.1 — What NVivo is

NVivo is a qualitative data analysis package that helps you organise, code, classify, retrieve and explore a corpus. It takes interview transcripts, focus groups, documents, audio and video files, images and open-ended survey responses. Its main value is making a large corpus easier to handle.

NVIVO CAN

- Organise the corpus into sources and folders
- Create and manage a coding structure
- Retrieve every extract for a code instantly
- Compare data across participants or groups
- Explore relationships between codes
- Visualise certain aspects of the corpus
- Keep a record of the analytical process
- Export coded data and results

NVIVO CANNOT

- Frame your research question
- Determine what participants meant
- Automatically identify the “right” themes
- Replace your interpretation
- Guarantee the quality of the analysis
- Justify a methodological choice for you

2.2 — Terminology

TERM	FRANÇAIS	IN NVIVO
Source / File	Source	A document or file imported into the project.
Code / Node	Code / nœud	A label designating a meaningful segment of data.
Coding	Codage	The act of assigning a code to a segment.
Case	Cas	The unit of analysis: a participant, a couple, a patient, an organisation.
Attribute	Attribut	A characteristic of a case: age, group, sex, time point.
Memo	Mémo	An analytical note attached to a source or a code — where the reflexive journal lives.
Annotation	Annotation	A comment pinned to a specific passage, like a margin note.
Theme	Thème	A shared pattern of meaning identified across the coded data. NVivo does not distinguish it from a code: you are the one who places it at the top of the tree.

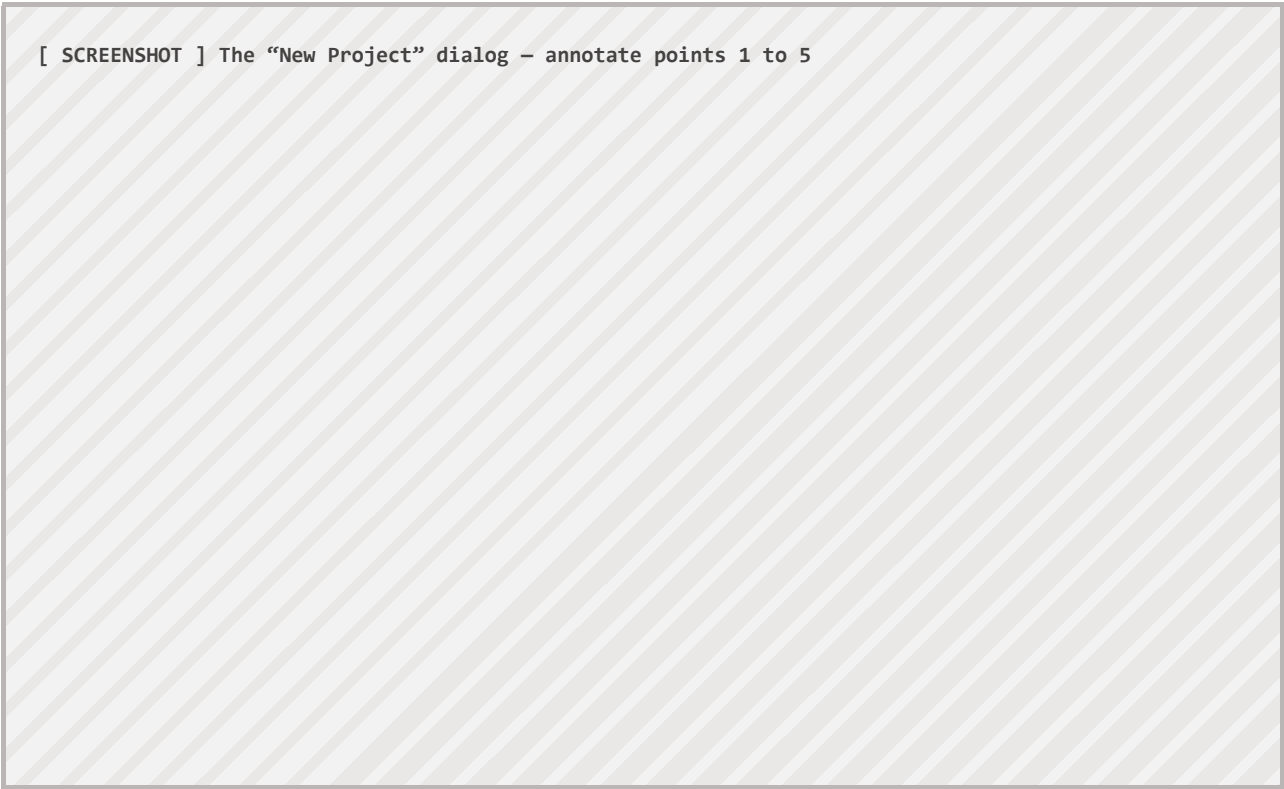
Terminology varies between versions. This guide follows NVivo 14.

3 Starting a project

3.1 — Creating the project

- 01 Open NVivo, then **New Project**.
- 02 Name your project however you like.
The description is optional but useful: research question, corpus, coders, and so on.
- 03 Choose where the .nvp file lives: a dedicated research folder.
- 04 Set the language of the data: it drives text analysis and stop words.
- 05 Configure auto-save and document recovery.

[SCREENSHOT] The “New Project” dialog – annotate points 1 to 5

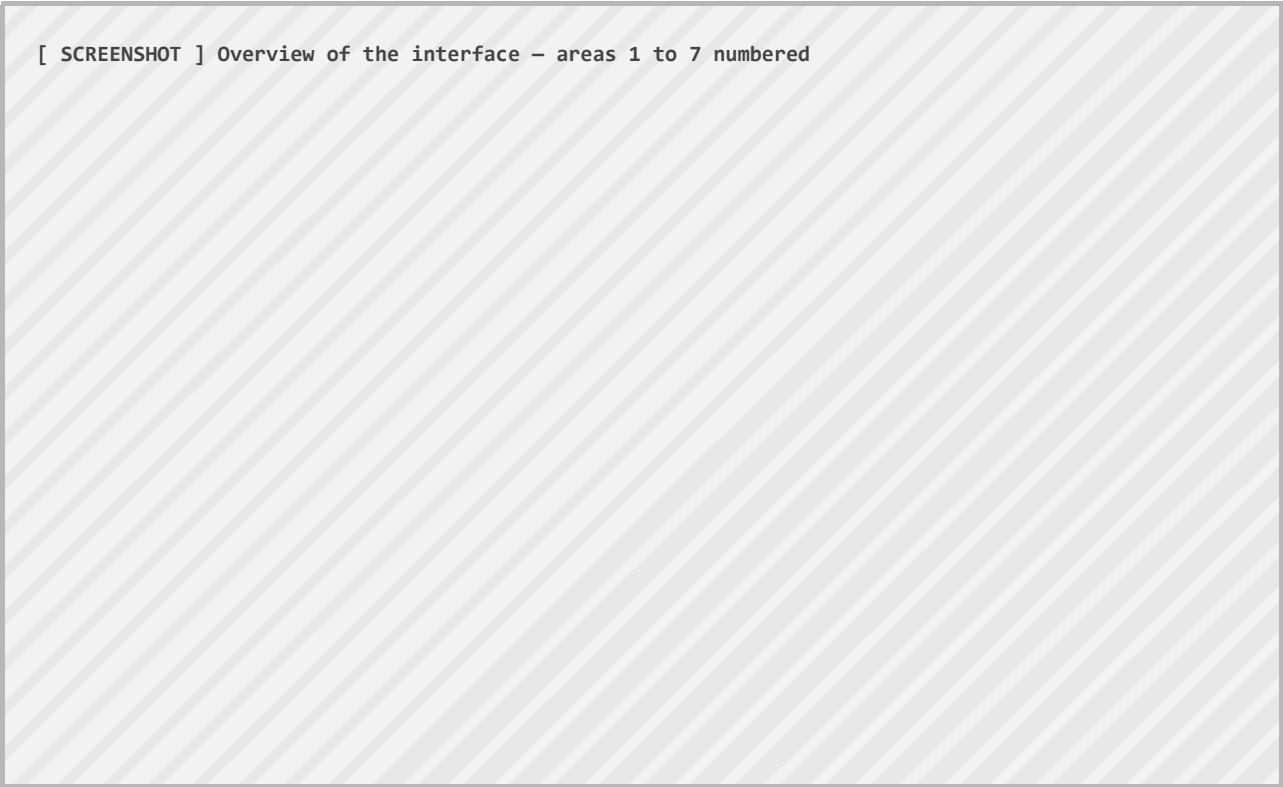


3.2 — Finding your way around

The look may vary slightly between versions, but the layout stays the same: a ribbon of actions at the top, a navigation pane on the left, the item list in the middle, the detail on the right.

NO.	AREA	WHAT IT IS FOR
1	Navigation	Reaching the project's sections.
2	Data / Sources	Imported files, organised in folders.
3	Codes / Nodes	The coding structure, made hierarchical by drag and drop.
4	Cases and Files classifications	Cases and their attributes — what makes group comparison possible.
5	Notes (Memos, Annotations)	Analytical notes and the reflexive journal.
6	Queries	Extracts for a code, cross-tabulations, coder comparison.
7	Visualisations / Reports	Charts, maps and exports.

[SCREENSHOT] Overview of the interface – areas 1 to 7 numbered



4 Importing interviews

4.1 — Prepare the files before importing

Five minutes of preparation saves hours of rework: once sources are coded, renaming or replacing a file becomes expensive.

CHECK BEFORE IMPORTING

Transcripts have been proofread and corrected (see the Whisper guide, §8.3)

All proper nouns are pseudonymised

File names follow one convention: P012_T1

One consistent format

Speaker turns are marked the same way throughout (I : / P :)

4.2 — Importing

01 Import tab, then **Files** (or drag and drop into the target folder).

02 Select the files; importing several at once is possible.

03 Check that each source opens and that the text is complete.

04 File the sources into the folders you planned.

05 Save, then make a dated copy of the project before you start coding.

4.3 — Create cases and their attributes

This often-skipped step is what makes any group comparison possible later (§8.2). A *case* is the unit of analysis — here a participant; the *attributes* describe that case.

CASE	GROUP	TIME	AGE	INTERVIEW LENGTH
P012	Intervention	T1	34	54 min
P013	Control	T1	41	47 min
P014	Intervention	T2	29	61 min

5 Coding

5.1 — What is a code?

A code is a label capturing the meaning or content of a segment of data. It has to be specific enough to say something, and general enough to be used again elsewhere in the corpus.

EXAMPLE

“Since the intervention, we communicate more easily.”

THE CODE

Improved communication

TOO NARROW

“Talks more easily since the intervention”.

TOO BROAD

“Change” says nothing about what changed.

5.2 — Creating and managing codes

In NVivo, codes are nodes, organised into a hierarchy by drag and drop. Four useful questions before creating a new one:

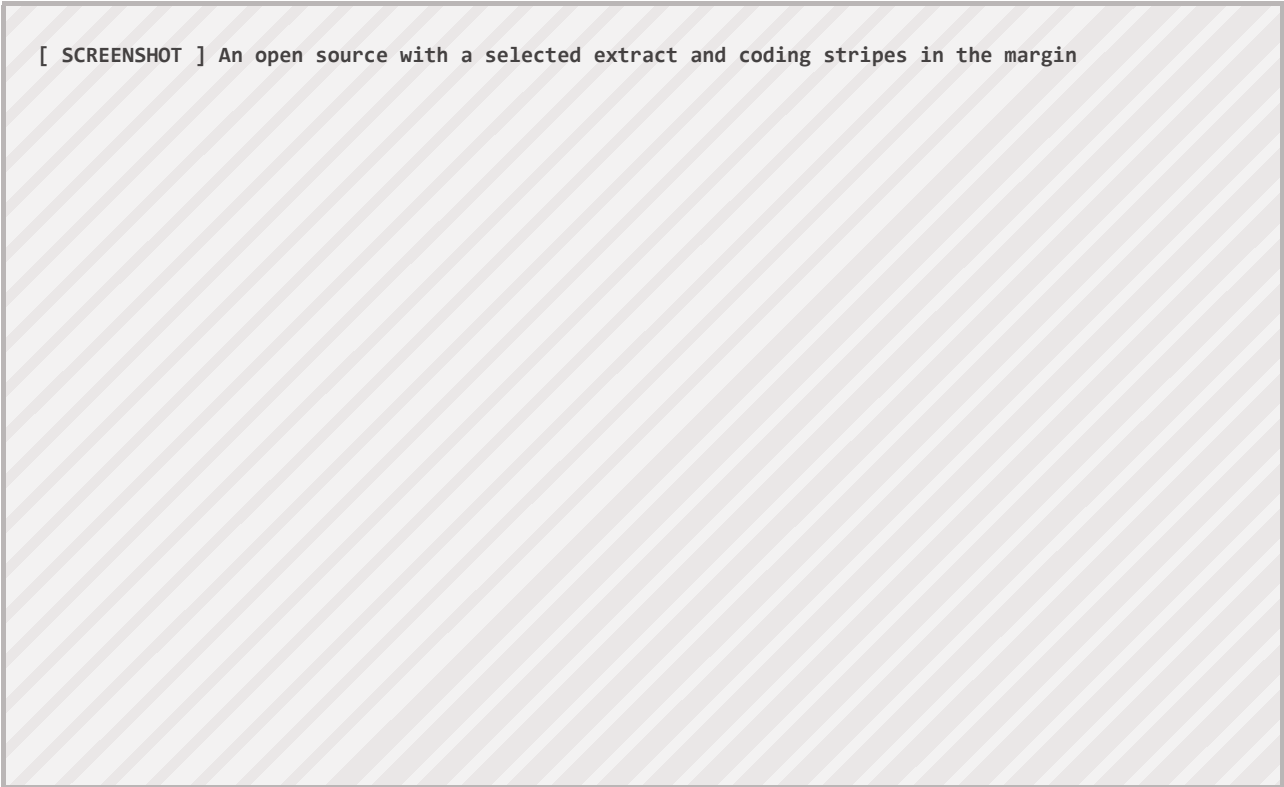
-
- 01 Is it relevant to the research question?
 - 02 Would its name be understood by someone other than me?
 - 03 Does it carry only one idea?
 - 04 Could I apply it to a comparable extract elsewhere in the corpus?
-

5.3 — Coding an extract

-
- 01 Open the source.
 - 02 Select the segment concerned.
 - 03 Click **Code**, or drag the selection onto the code you want.
 - 04 Check the coded extract by opening the code: coding stripes appear in the source's margin.
-

One passage can belong to several codes when it carries several relevant meanings.

[SCREENSHOT] An open source with a selected extract and coding stripes in the margin

The image is a large rectangular area with a light gray background and diagonal gray stripes. It represents a placeholder for a screenshot of the NVivo software interface, where a document is open, a text extract is selected, and coding stripes are visible in the margin.

5.4 — Revising and changing codes

Coding is iterative. As the corpus progresses it is normal to merge close codes, rename them, split ones that have grown too broad, move them to another category, or delete ones no longer in use. Refining the frame is part of the work — it is not the sign of bad coding.

RECORDING THE DECISIONS

Logging every creation, merge, rename or change of scope in a memo, with the date and the reason, can be useful when writing the paper. Faced with a reviewer, it may supply what is needed to answer certain requests.

6 Building the thematic tree

6.1 — From codes to categories, from categories to themes

Themes are built by spotting broader patterns of meaning across the data. The climb in generality reads across three levels:

CODES

what the extracts say

More dialogue

Better listening

Fewer arguments

Easier silences

CATEGORY

what they share

Changes in communication

THEME

what it means

A calmer relationship

6.2 — A full tree, as it looks in NVivo

In the **Codes** pane, the hierarchy is built by dragging one code onto another. Here is the example project's structure once organised:

THEME 1	A calmer relationship	[42]
└─	Changes in communication	[24]
└─	More dialogue	[9]
└─	Better listening	[7]
└─	Easier silences	[8]
└─	Handling disagreement	[18]
└─	Fewer arguments	[11]
└─	Conflict avoidance	[7]
THEME 2	A redistributed load	[31]
└─	Sharing of tasks	[17]
└─	Recognising the other's effort	[14]
THEME 3	Doubt about how long the gains will last	[19]
└─	Fear of sliding back	[12]
└─	Wanting follow-up	[7]
PENDING		[6]
└─	To settle – “role of the extended family”	[6]

7 Ensuring analytical quality

7.1 — Reflexivity and the researcher's position

Qualitative analysis rests on interpretation. It is therefore a matter of staying aware of how one's own perspectives, expectations and theoretical assumptions shape the reading of the data. Keeping analytical notes or a reflexive journal keeps a record of that.

In NVivo, **memos** are where this belongs: one memo attached to the project for the journal, one memo per source for reading impressions, one memo per theme to document how it was built.

7.2 — Inter-coder agreement

When several researchers code the same corpus, their coding can be compared to discuss convergences and divergences, then resolve disagreements through an explicit process.

THE STATUS OF THE CALCULATION DEPENDS ON YOUR APPROACH

Braun and Clarke do not recommend computing an agreement coefficient within *reflexive TA*: for them, coder convergence is not an indicator of interpretive quality. Some journals may nonetheless ask for it. Two possible answers: compute and report it, or explicitly justify its absence on the basis of the methodological framework adopted. Either way, the position must be decided before coding and written into the Method section.

If your methodology provides for it, reliability is assessed **early** in coding, to check that everyone understands and applies the codes the same way. That is the moment to adjust the thematic tree before coding the whole corpus.

-
- 01** Select a subset, typically **10 to 20%** of the data: a few whole interviews, or representative extracts covering varied situations.
 - 02** Check that this subset properly reflects the diversity of the material (groups, time points, profiles).
 - 03** Each coder codes it **independently**, with the same frame, without consulting the others during this phase.
 - 04** Compare the coding with the dedicated query, then discuss the divergences (7.2.3).
-

7.2.1 — Running a Coding Comparison Query

- 01** **Explore** (or **Query**) tab > **Coding Comparison**.
 - 02** Choose the two users (groups A and B) to compare.
 - 03** Select the sources concerned — the subset, not the whole project.
-

04 Select the codes (nodes) to compare.

05 Run the query.

06 NVivo displays a results table and computes a kappa coefficient directly.

TECHNICAL PREREQUISITE

Comparison is only possible if each coder works under their **own NVivo user account**. Check this in the preferences *before* starting: coding attributed to the wrong user cannot easily be reassigned.

7.2.2 — Reading the two metrics

METRIC	WHAT IT MEASURES	USE
Percentage agreement	Share of segments on which both coders applied the same code: number of agreements / total units analysed.	A simple estimate, useful internally
Cohen's kappa	Agreement between two coders corrected for chance agreement. Usually ranges from 0 to 1.	The metric expected in papers. A kappa above 0.70 is generally considered acceptable.

Usual benchmarks: < 0.40 poor · 0.40–0.60 moderate · 0.60–0.75 good · > 0.75 excellent (Fleiss et al., 2003).

7.2.3 — Interpreting a low kappa

A low kappa does not mean the coding is “wrong”. Most often it indicates that code definitions are not clear enough, that coders interpret certain passages differently, or that the frame needs adjusting.

Discussing the divergences then makes it possible to clarify categories, to change, merge or delete codes, and to improve the kappa.

AFTER THE COMPARISON

Once the frame is stable and its reliability judged satisfactory, the rest of the corpus can be coded, by one person or split between several coders, as the project requires. Note in the decisions memo which version of the frame was used, and from which interview onwards.

7.3 — More than two coders

The *Coding Comparison Query* only compares two coders at a time. Beyond that, proceed by pairwise comparisons:

Coder A vs Coder B	→	$\kappa = 0.74$
Coder A vs Coder C	→	$\kappa = 0.68$
Coder B vs Coder C	→	$\kappa = 0.71$
mean	→	$\kappa = 0.71$

8 Exploring and visualising

8.1 — Coding queries

Queries are used to examine how the data was coded: retrieving every extract attached to a code, examining relationships between codes, or spotting regularities across participants. Three common uses:

QUESTION	QUERY	SETUP
Everything said about X	Coding Query	One code, all sources.
Do X and Y appear together?	Coding Query with AND / NEAR	Two codes; <i>NEAR</i> finds co-occurrences in the same passage.
Who talks about X?	Coding Query filtered by attribute	One code, restricted to a group or a time point (§4.3).

8.2 — Matrix queries

A matrix compares coding patterns across groups or characteristics: themes in rows, study groups in columns. It surfaces differences or similarities in how the coded content is distributed.

THEME	INTERVENTION (N = 12)	CONTROL (N = 11)
A calmer relationship	31	11
A redistributed load	19	12
Doubt about how long the gains will last	14	5

Table 4 – themes × groups matrix, number of coded extracts.

DO NOT READ A MATRIX AS A STATISTICAL TEST

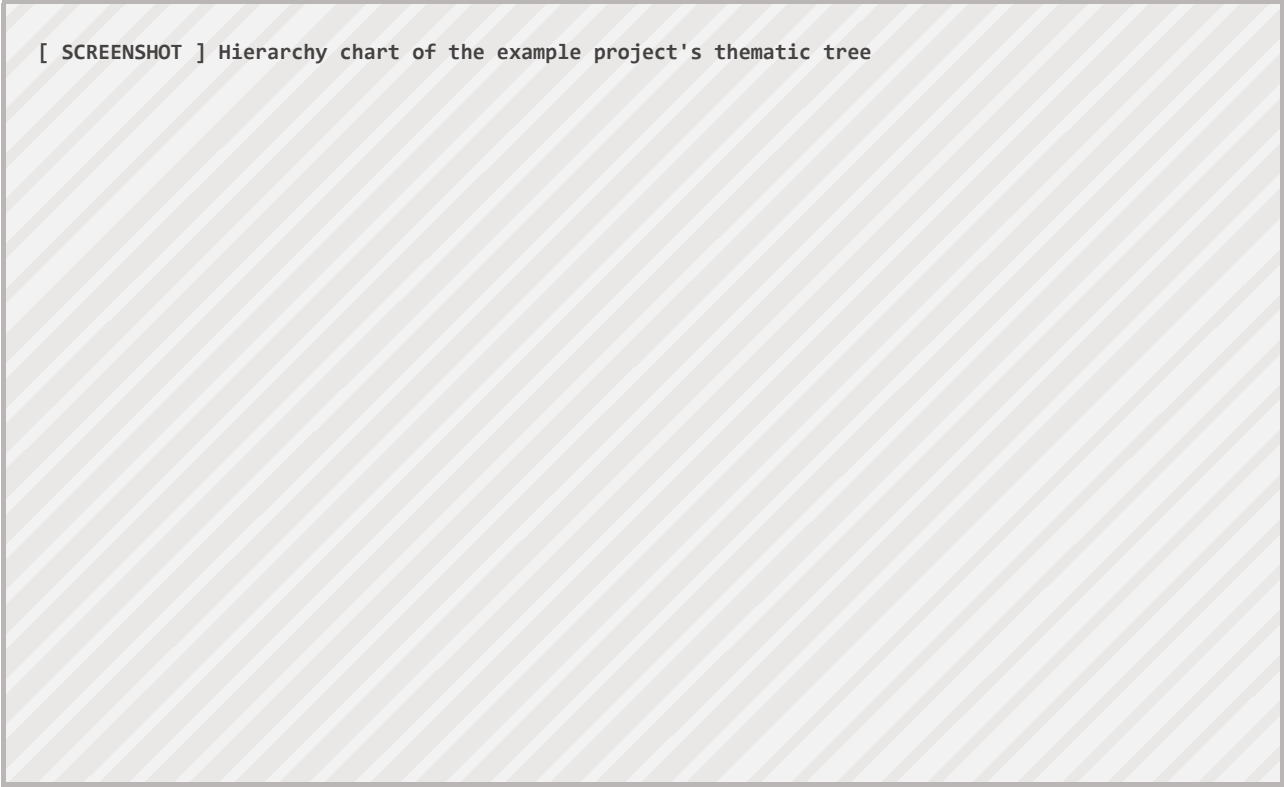
Frequency gaps are interpreted against the qualitative context. A heavily coded theme may reflect the length of an interview or the way questions were asked, not necessarily a difference between groups. The matrix serves to **steer the rereading** of the extracts, not to conclude.

8.3 — Charts, word clouds and maps

TOOL	WHAT IT SHOWS	LIMIT TO KEEP IN MIND
Word cloud	Word frequency across the corpus: the most used appear largest. Useful for a first sweep.	A word's frequency says nothing about its analytical weight. Never a finding in itself.
Hierarchy chart	The relative weight of the thematic tree's branches, by area.	Reflects the coding, not the theme's importance.
Coding charts	The distribution of codes, the frequency of certain themes, comparisons between participant groups.	Same precautions as for the matrix (§8.2).
Concept maps	The relationships between themes, categories and concepts, which you draw yourself.	Excellent support for team discussion; export it for the paper.
Project maps	The links between project items: which codes co-occur, which sources carry which themes.	Quickly unreadable beyond about fifteen items.

These visualisations are exploratory tools: they should support qualitative interpretation, not replace it.

[SCREENSHOT] Hierarchy chart of the example project's thematic tree



9 Exporting and reporting

9.1 — What exports

NVivo exports coded extracts and a range of project information: extracts per code, node summaries, coding reports, query results, tables, visualisations. Usual formats: .docx for extracts, .xlsx for matrices, .png for charts.

9.2 — What can be written in a paper's Method section

- 01 The thematic-analysis approach adopted, with its reference.
 - 02 Whether coding was inductive, deductive or mixed.
 - 03 The number of coders, their discipline, and how disagreements were resolved.
 - 04 Whether an agreement coefficient was used, and its justification (§7.2).
 - 05 The software and its version
 - 06 A sentence of reflexivity on the researchers' position relative to the field.
-

10

Common mistakes and fixes

SYMPTOM	WHAT TO DO
I cannot find my imported files	Open the <i>Data / Sources</i> section and check where the import was directed.
I coded the wrong passage	Select the coding concerned and remove it or change its assignment (<i>Uncode</i>).
I created too many similar codes	Review the list and merge those carrying the same concept (<i>Merge into</i>).
Coding Comparison offers only one user	The coders worked under the same account. Create one account per coder before redoing the subset (§7.2.1).
My themes look like my interview guide	A classic sign that coding stayed descriptive. Take each theme and look for what it says about lived experience, beyond the question asked.

11

Appendices

11.1 — Reflexive journal (possible template)

DATE & SOURCES CODED —

WHAT STRUCK ME What surprised, unsettled or moved me in these interviews

CODING DECISIONS Codes created, merged, renamed — and why

MY ASSUMPTIONS What expectation might I have projected onto the data today?

OPEN QUESTIONS To settle next session or in a team meeting

NEXT STEP —

These entries feed directly into the reflexivity sentence expected in the Method section (§9.2, item 06).

11.2 — Glossary EN / FR

ENGLISH / IN NVIVO	FRANÇAIS	DEFINITION
Thematic analysis (TA)	Analyse thématique	A method for identifying and interpreting patterns of meaning.
Coding tree / hierarchy	Arbre thématique	Hierarchical organisation of codes, categories and themes.
Coding framework	Grille de codage	The set of codes and their application rules at a given time.
Codebook	Dictionnaire de codes	A document defining each code, its criteria and an example.
Coded reference	Extrait codé	A segment of a source attached to a code; the unit NVivo counts.
Co-occurrence (NEAR)	Cooccurrence	Two codes present together on the same passage.
Inter-coder agreement	Accord inter-codeurs	How far two independent codings of the same material converge.
Cohen's kappa (κ)	Kappa de Cohen	A chance-corrected agreement coefficient, from 0 to 1.
Reflexivity	Réflexivité	Explicit examination of the researcher's influence on the analysis.
Saturation	Saturation	The point where new data yields no new code. A discussed notion in <i>reflexive TA</i> .
Inductive / data-driven	Codage inductif	Codes built from the data, with no prior frame.
Deductive / theory-driven	Codage déductif	Codes drawn from a theoretical framework set in advance.

11.3 — References

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Over to you. An error not listed here, a setting that changed between versions, an example worth adding? Report it for the next edition of this guide.

END OF GUIDE